resentment and opposition. He promoted Hindus against the advice of Muslim advisers, and Shias against the inclination of the orthodox Sunnis, and stood up to the petty bickering of the ulema, all to the glory of the Mughal Empire which, by the end of the sixteenth century, saw a hundred metric tons of silver flowing into the country from European powers buying manufactured products as well as natural resources. The unimaginable wealth and the quality of the goods of the Mughal Empire drew merchants and travellers from around the world. Rembrandt would be influenced by the luminous paintings of the Mughal court, the world would get its first translation of the Mahabharat into Persian through the *Razmnama*, and the West would discover the Upanishads through the translations of Dara Shukoh, Akbar's great-grandson.

As each new region was incorporated into the Mughal Empire, it added a sliver of local colour to the court culture which became, by the end of the sixteenth century, a cauldron of different rituals, textures, and nuances. Over time, this became the dominant feature in various sub-imperial courts. Everywhere in the empire, rulers and governors incorporated elements into the way they ruled, through marriages, political alliances, and cultural exchanges.

The different parts of the country were physically connected through the building of roads, dak chaukis, and sarais, and were linguistically connected by Persian, which became the administrative language of the empire even in the smallest of towns. In this fashion, Mughal culture became infused with the taste and texture of Hindustan to create a distinctive hybrid culture that embodied the various strands of the subcontinent as also the ancestral lands of the Mughals. And so, delicately flavoured Central Asian dishes fused with local cooking techniques and spices to create a distinct cuisine, today bastardized in countless 'Mughlai' restaurants across the globe. Mongol lutes and flutes met the Hindustani veena and raags and Dhrupad music became the rage in the sixteenth century. Brajbhasha phrases sneaked into imperial vocabulary and Persian idioms were adopted by Rajasthani court poets. The clothes in the Rajput courts, the weapons in the battlefields, the nuances of language, the blending of styles in architecture and painting all formed a new Mughal culture so variously layered that even today, it would be impossible to cleave this identity into its separate parts.

In 1578, at the age of thirty-six, Akbar experienced a spiritual epiphany during a qumargha hunt. This brought about a distinct change in the way he